

Figure 13: Governor Arthur Lawley

In 1906, forty-six-year-old Arthur Lawley (Figure 13) took over as governor of Madras Presidency. An experienced administrator, Lawley had served in South Africa and Australia for about a decade before arriving in Madras. If the first rumblings of the Swadeshi storm were beginning to be heard at the time of his arrival, by the time he demitted office in late 1912, the movement had been crushed. (His repressive tenure notwithstanding, Lawley figures benignly in some of R.K. Narayan's Malgudi stories with a road named after him and a statue in his honour.[1]) In the first two years of the Swadeshi shipping business, the higher officials in the Government of Madras did not intervene directly though they followed developments and endorsed the biased actions of the local administration. But this changed when V.O. Chidambaram Pillai's politics shifted gear. While VOC married politics and Swadeshi business right from the outset, from late 1907, his politics took a more radical turn. The famous split in the Congress between the Moderates and the Extremists—with the latter disappointed by the lack of progress in acquiring political rights arguing for popular agitation while the former advocated peaceful constitutional methods—marks this turn.

The colonial state chose this moment to strike. This change is indexed by the appointment of the experienced Lionel Maling Wynch as collector and magistrate of Tirunelveli in December 1907. Born in 1864, Wynch, like